Psychologist-Client Services Agreement and Informed Consent

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Welcome

Before beginning psychotherapy, I want you to have a clear understanding of what to expect from our work together, including the services I provide, confidentiality, and my practice policies. Please review this agreement carefully and bring up any questions or concerns. Your signature indicates that you have reviewed this information and consent to treatment.

About My Practice

I provide individual psychotherapy for adults experiencing a range of psychological, emotional, relational, and health-related concerns. I also work with couples and families navigating the impact of chronic, complex, or progressive medical conditions.

My approach is collaborative and individualized, drawing from cognitive-behavioral, acceptance-based, interpersonal, and psychodynamic approaches. I believe that understanding a person's experiences within the broader context of their life is an important part of meaningful therapeutic work.

The Psychotherapy Process

Psychotherapy begins with an initial assessment of your concerns, history, goals, and current circumstances. Together, we will consider what you hope to gain from treatment and develop an approach that fits your needs.

Therapy may involve discussing difficult experiences, emotions, relationships, or patterns of behavior. Although psychotherapy can lead to meaningful improvements in well-being and functioning, it may also involve periods of discomfort, and specific outcomes cannot be guaranteed.

You are encouraged to ask questions, provide feedback, and discuss concerns about our work at any time. You have the right to participate in treatment decisions, decline particular interventions, or discontinue treatment.

Appointments

Sessions are 50 minutes long and are offered in person at my Sellwood office in Portland, Oregon or through telehealth.

Appointment frequency will be determined collaboratively based on your needs and availability.

Cancellation and Missed Appointments

Please provide at least 24 hours' notice if you need to cancel or reschedule an appointment.

Appointments canceled with less than 24 hours' notice, or missed without notice, will be subject to a cancellation fee equal to the usual session fee ($180). A one-time exception will be provided for the first late cancellation or missed appointment.

Insurance generally does not cover missed appointments or late cancellation fees. These charges are the client's responsibility, subject to applicable insurance contracts and legal requirements.

Confidentiality
Your privacy is an essential part of psychotherapy. Information shared during treatment is confidential and will not ordinarily be disclosed without your authorization.

There are circumstances in which disclosure may be required or permitted by law, including certain situations involving suspected abuse or neglect, serious safety concerns, court proceedings, and other legal obligations.

Information may also be shared as permitted for treatment, payment, and healthcare operations. When appropriate, I may consult with other professionals to support your care while taking steps to protect your privacy.

Additional information about confidentiality, permitted disclosures, and your rights is provided in my Notice of Privacy Practices.

Couples and Family Psychotherapy
Couples and family psychotherapy may be offered when a medical condition affects the well-being and functioning of the individual and their loved ones. Treatment may focus on supporting adjustment to illness, navigating changes in relationships and family roles, and addressing the emotional challenges associated with illness and caregiving.

When multiple people participate in treatment, we will clarify the goals of therapy, who is considered the client, and expectations regarding confidentiality. We will also discuss how individual disclosures and requests for clinical records will be handled, consistent with applicable legal and ethical requirements.

Communication Between Sessions
Email may be used for scheduling, billing, and other administrative matters. Because ordinary email can involve privacy risks, I encourage you to reserve sensitive clinical concerns for our scheduled appointments.

I generally respond to nonurgent messages within two business days. Messages are not monitored continuously, including during evenings, weekends, and holidays.

Please do not use email to communicate emergencies or situations requiring immediate clinical attention.

Social Media and Professional Boundaries
To protect your privacy and maintain appropriate professional boundaries, I do not communicate with clients through social media or accept friend or connection requests on personal social media accounts. Please use my practice email for scheduling and other administrative matters. Clinical concerns are best discussed during scheduled appointments.

Emergencies
My private practice does not provide emergency or crisis services, and I cannot guarantee immediate availability between appointments.

If you are experiencing an immediate emergency, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department. For mental health crisis support, you may call or text 988.

If your clinical needs require more intensive or immediate services than my practice can provide, we will discuss appropriate treatment options or referrals.

Telehealth Services
Telehealth appointments are conducted through an appropriate secure video platform. Telehealth may provide greater convenience and accessibility, but it also carries potential limitations, including technical difficulties, interruptions, privacy risks, and reduced ability to respond directly during emergencies.

You are encouraged to attend telehealth sessions from a private, quiet location where others cannot overhear our conversation. At the beginning of telehealth appointments, I will confirm your physical location and a means of contacting you in case of emergency or technical interruption.

Telehealth services can only be provided when you are physically located in a jurisdiction where I am legally authorized to practice.

You may discuss the suitability of telehealth with me at any time.

Clinical Records
I maintain confidential clinical records documenting assessment, treatment, and progress. Records are stored electronically using systems and safeguards intended to protect your information.

You have rights regarding access to your records, requests for corrections, and other matters described in my Notice of Privacy Practices.

Audio or video recording of sessions requires prior agreement. I do not record psychotherapy sessions.

Coordination of Care
At times, it may be helpful to coordinate with other healthcare professionals involved in your care. When authorization is required, I will obtain your permission before sharing information.

Coordination may be particularly useful when psychological concerns intersect with medical conditions, chronic pain, or other aspects of physical health.

Ending Therapy
The duration of psychotherapy varies according to individual needs and goals. You may choose to discontinue treatment at any time.

When possible, I encourage discussing the decision to end therapy so that we can review your progress, address any remaining concerns, and consider additional resources or referrals.

If I determine that your needs would be better served by another provider or level of care, I will discuss this with you and make reasonable efforts to support an appropriate transition.

Consent for Treatment

By electronically acknowledging this agreement, I confirm that:

- I have reviewed this agreement and understand the general nature, potential benefits, and risks of psychotherapy.
- I understand the policies regarding appointments, cancellations, communication, confidentiality, and emergencies.
- I understand the additional considerations associated with telehealth services.
- I have had the opportunity to ask questions.
- I voluntarily consent to receive psychological services from Dr. Kate Shirley.